

Postcolonialism and Representation of Identity in Bapsi Sidhwa's *Water*



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Declaration

I declare that the work presented in the dissertation titled ‘Postcolonialism and representation of Identity’ in Bapsi Sidhwa’s *Water*’ being submitted to the Department of English School of Languages Doon University, Dehradun for the award of Bachelor in English in my original research work

The dissertation embodies the result of my investigations, observations, and experiments carried out by me. I have not plagiarized any part of the dissertation nor have submitted some work for the award of any other degree/diploma anywhere.

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Certificate

This is to certify that the dissertation entitled “Postcolonialism and Representation of Identity in Bapsi Sidhwa’s Water” submitted by Aahana Srivastava has been done under my supervision. It is also certified that the work in this dissertation embodies the original research and hard work of the candidate. The assistance and support received during the course of the investigation and all the sources of literature have been fully acknowledged.

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Introduction

Bapsi Sidhwa's *Water* is a powerful lens through which we can critique and analyze the partial and casteist social structure in 1930s India. The novel, written in 2006, follows a group of widows living in an ashram on the banks of Varanasi. The major plot of the book revolves around Chuhiya, a six-year-old bride who was widowed only after 2 years of her marriage. As she explores the ashram while insisting in self-prophecy, that she is not staying there for long and as the novel ends we bid farewell to her as she leaves Varanasi with Mahatma Gandhi's followers. The novel ends with one of the characters, Shakuntala saying "Make sure she's in Gandhiji's care" (198). The widows, whose lives have stark differences as brides and daughters of wealthy families are forced to beg for their survival. As one of the widows Shakuntala remarks "It's her first time" (97), and "she'll get used to it" (97). The novel also divulges into the lives of other characters, most of whom are widows who are destitute, helpless, and trapped by their situations. One of these characters is Kalyani, the youngest widow in the ashram, before Chuhiya's arrival. She is regularly forced to work as a prostitute at the behest of Madhumati, the leader of the ashram. She is trapped in a cycle of abuse and eventually reaches a sad end as she commits suicide. The rest of the characters have very similar stories of helplessness. These stories make the reader understand the true depth of their suffering. One of the most heart-wrenching is that of Patirajji, whose entire life seemed to revolve around her want to eat a laddoo, though very little is given about it can easily be assumed that she lived a life similar to Chuhiya, and her life and eventual death could have been Chuhiya's future if she had not escaped the ashram.

The creation of this novel is an interesting story in itself. The book is based on the script of the movie titled *Water* (2005). Directed and written by Deepa Mehta, the movie was initially planned to be shot in 2000, and faced turmoil and destruction in the hands of about 2000 bhaktas,

storming the Ghats. The mob was led by a right-wing politician, Arun Pathak. In defense of the director, the author wrote a scathing letter entitled “They are punishing Deepa for deflating their egos,” published on May 19, 2000, in Hindustan Times. The letter carefully dissects and takes down all the accusations against the film made by Right-wing groups, but also carefully supports the director in her ventures. She writes “It is a love story beset by the kind of injustices and misunderstandings that hound the path of true love in the time-honored tradition of tragic storytelling. Of all her films, *Water* is perhaps the least likely to offend anyone”. (Sidhwa 135)

The author also recalls her previous experience of working with the director, with the adaption of her book *Ice-Candy Man*. The sharp defense ends up hitting the main vein of the matter with the sentence “Perhaps a vengeful patriarchy is still punishing her for deflating their egos in her film *Fire*?”. (136) .

Eventually, she is hired by the production company as a marketing tactic to make the movie into a book. She manages to finish in a mere three months and is finally published in 2006 a full six years after she defends the film.

The book demonstrates how different social identities intersect and shape the lives of individuals in a colonial society, and how these experiences shape the power dynamics and hierarchies in the era. This analysis focuses on how the postcolonial narratives formed and inevitably were the reason for the way the widows lived the life they did. The novel also explores how people that lived outside the system of abuse that is the ashram, also faced similar situations and were subjected to the system. The novel examines under the lens of post-colonial theory with a focus on Gayatri Chakravarty Spivak’s “Can the subaltern speak.” argues how instead of whether or not the subaltern* can speak rather if they are heard. subaltern according to Spivak as "The term 'subaltern' is used to indicate a position of social, political, and cultural inferiority in a given social hierarchy."¹One of the core principles of postcolonialism is making the reader aware of the blind

spots present in their cultural understanding but, also showing the lasting impact of colonialism on the colonized.

The other aspect of this research will focus on the Intersectional analysis of the novel. Intersectionality in the words of Patricia Hill Collins and Sirma Bilge, "Intersectionality as an analytical tool gives people better access to the complexity of the world and themselves."³

Intersectionality is better understood as how a person, particularly a female, is subjected to a single source but instead, several factors are the culprit behind her pitiful existence. The novel describes the systematic violence the widows rather than the women suffer through. Additionally, the novel talks about the internal structural hierarchies present within the place that is supposed to protect them equally. As shown in the status of Madhu-Didi and Shakuntala, who got additional monetary support from outside. Further explained in the article Towards a Field of Intersectionality Studies: Theory, Applications, and Praxis, Crenshaw explains that "the overlapping structures of subordination revealed how certain groups of women were made particularly vulnerable to abuse."

Similarly, the novel *Water* reveals a sheer failure of the religious institution (ashram, a place for widows) that normalizes Hindu widows' exclusion. Such "structural intersectionality" seems to reach the largely unchecked powers that normalized unjust domination.

\This dissertation aims to explore the representation of identity in Bapsi Sidhwa's *Water* and how it reflects the power dynamics and hierarchies present in colonial India during the 1930s. Using postcolonialism's subaltern theory and intersectionality theory, this dissertation will examine how gender, caste, and religion intersect and shape the experiences of individuals in colonial society. This dissertation hypothesis how Bapsi Sidhwa's *Water* provides a view through which we analyze and understand the complex social and cultural dynamics of postcolonial

societies. The novel exposes the intersections of gender, caste, and religion and their impact on the lives of disadvantaged individuals.

Through a thorough examination of the novel, the dissertation aims to showcase how postcolonial narratives are essential in understanding the complex social and cultural dynamics of postcolonial India. It argues how the book *Water* is an essential tool in explaining how different social identities intersect and shape the experiences of individuals in a colonial society, and how these experiences are shaped by power dynamics and hierarchies.

The following chapters will focus on analyzing the book on both the subaltern and intersectional scales. The chapters will also examine the themes of identity, power internal hierarchies, and resistance through the eyes of Chuhiya, the child protagonist who still does not understand the scope of her world, but through her eyes, we can catch glimpses of the era.

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Chapter 1: Postcolonial Perspectives on Identity Representation in Bapsi Sidhwa's *Water*

The rise of postcolonialism rose out of the fall of the colonies. Postcolonialism is a theory that critically examines the cultural implication of colonialism and its aftereffects. The theory mainly focuses on social, cultural, and political implications and interrogates the power dynamics, hierarchies, and subjections of the colonies and how these power structures continue to affect and shape the lives of individuals living in the previous colonies. Postcolonial theory as defined by Ania Loomba, postcolonialism refers to "the study of the historical, cultural, and political legacies of colonialism and how these legacies continue to impact societies and individuals in the present" (1). The theory focuses on the issues of identity culture and representation but also the present-day efforts on decolonization, cultural autonomy, and social justice.

The main power of postcolonialism lies in its ability to look at the text through a different lens, as said by Chinua Achebe in his work "An Image of Africa: Racism in Conrad's 'Heart of Darkness'". where he recalls a black person cheering on a white person's very racist journey. He says "Joseph Conrad was a thoroughgoing racist. That this simple truth is glossed over in criticisms of his work is due to the fact that white racism against Africa is such a normal way of thinking that its manifestations go completely unnoticed." Also, the theory aims to showcase the lingering influence of colonialism, along with showing the truth to the reader but also denouncing the imperialistic effects on the present.

The novel *Water* is an excellent example of colonial influence on pre-independent India in the 1930s. The British influence is never openly showcased in the novel but is felt throughout the novel. The novel's backdrop serves as a painful and powerful reminder of a bitter past, but it is the very thing helping us uncover the ways power operates, hierarchies are reinforced and marginalized voices are silenced and suppressed.

Gayatri Chakravarty Spivak's seminal work titled "Can the subaltern speak?" is an interrogation of the representation and agency of the marginalized, particularly women, in both

colonial and postcolonial contexts. The essay first published in 1988, has now been converted into a foundational text within the postcolonial academic sphere. The essay introduces the concept of the subaltern, essentially people or cultures who have been marginalized and rendered virtually special in the annals of power. As stated by Cary Nelson and Lawrence Grossberg in their introduction to the collection "Marxism and the Interpretation of Culture", Spivak's essay "has been one of the most widely read and influential texts in the debates around colonial and postcolonial studies" (271).

The core of Spivak's argument lies in the concept of subaltern which she borrows from Antonio Gramsci's theory of cultural hegemony. She reworks Gramsci's arguments and focuses on the subaltern which is described as a group especially rendered voiceless by the power structures and cultural hegemonies. She highlights the challenges and experiences and identities in the hegemonic discourse. She argues the problem is not whether or not the subaltern can speak but if the subaltern can be heard. According to her, the voices of subalterns are often silenced or distorted as they are excluded from the dominant narratives and rendered invisible within the socio-political hegemonies.

This essay provides a theoretical structure for understanding the complexities of representation and power dynamics within the postcolonial context. Spivak examines how the subaltern is marginalized through various mechanisms, like structural hegemonies, linguistic hurdles, and oppressive social frameworks. She uses the works of Michel Foucault and Jacques Derrida to get her point across. She critiques the essential notion of identity and explores how subaltern subjects are positioned with the dominant discourse.

In water, the widows in the ashram can be seen as subaltern figures, lingering on the margins of society due to their gender, caste, and widowhood. One of the characters, Madhumati, calls the widows half-dead in the lines "And when our husbands die, God help us, the wives also

half die” (42). The reasoning behind this thinking is hinted at the start when the mother of the protagonist, Chuhiya thought “She knew that in Brahmin culture, once widowed, a woman was deprived of her useful function in society—that of reproducing and fulfilling her duties to her husband. She ceased to exist as a person; she was no longer either daughter or daughter-in-law. There was no place for her in the community, and she was viewed as a threat to society” (24). And as Spivak argues, the subaltern struggle for agency and representation becomes particularly complex when intersected with multiple layers of repression, such as gender, caste, and religion.

The novel provides a pointed depiction of the widows' life and their struggles to make their voices heard and assert their own will within the constraints of their social and cultural contexts. Here, Spivak's ideas serve as a valuable tool, we can gain a deeper understanding of the widow's fight for their rights in a highly misogynistic and partial society. As she points out, a subaltern's struggle often suffers from resistance from the dominant groups.

One of the examples is the story of Shakuntala, she is depicted as one person in the higher strata of society. But she's also shown as a person who is highly religious and traditional. Her background as revealed in the course of the novel, is revealed to be an educated lady but is also resigned to her fate and cannot outwardly show her agency.

In conclusion, the ideas presented in Gayatri Spivak's essay help us analyze the puzzle of the widows' woes in a Pre-independence colonial India. The novel provides an insightful exploration of the widows' conditions and their struggle for free will within the intersecting power dynamics of gender caste and religion.

Within the pages of the novel, the widows are shown as pitiful marginalized creatures found voiceless by societal expectations and the social structure of colonized India. They exist on the fringes of society, confined to an ashram and the restrictive norms and traditions that limit their self-exploration. Their voices are not heard and are silenced by the power hegemonies.

One example of such subaltern exploration is Chuhiya the protagonist who was brought as a child widow to the ashram. Chuhiya's innocence and vulnerability highlight the oppressive nature of the social expectations imposed on the widows, as well as their subjugation and the voicelessness of women within the particular system. She has been introduced as a rebel to the system, she is the one insisting that she will leave the ashram soon and clinging to the innocent hope that her mother will come and serve her. Her experiences reflect the larger narrative of subalternity and the struggle for free will within colonial society.

The other major character suffering from subalternity is the character of Kalyani, she is forced to work as a prostitute by Madhumati the leader of the ashram. She is also ostracized by the other widows, because of her not being shaven. Even though, she is described as a well-wisher and a person who puts others first, as exemplified by her giving money for the old Patiraji's funeral. Otherwise, her body would have been dumped into the river Ganga. She tries to get out but is resigned to her fate. The only act of her performing her free will is the act of her as described in the book "Mother Ganga has claimed her daughter."

One of the characters Shakuntala quotes "It's men who create the sins and women who suffer for them." (94). This quote highlights the gendered power dynamics and the burden placed on women within the social and religious norms of the time, expanding on the marginalization and the subjugation of women within the narrative.

The characters and representation in "*Water*" provide precious insights into the power dynamics and the hierarchies present in colonial India and their influence on marginalized groups. Through their different opinions and experiences of the widows, the novel uncovers the intersections of gender, caste, and widowhood and the consequent marginalization of these individuals.

The imposed guilt on the widows is reflected clearly in the scenes where Chuhiya is first entering the ashram. It further deepened when one of the characters, Patirajji dies and one of the other widows' remarks "God Willing, she'll be reborn as a man" (117). This represents the imposition of guilt and control over the widows and illustrates the power dynamics at play.

The oppressive system is personified by the occurrence of two characters, the leader of the ashram Madhumati and the head priest of the ashram Sadanada. They suppress women's voices on two different levels, Madhumati employs fear and rough methods to suppress while Sadanada, despite appearing to look at their best interests is only using them to satisfy his lust.

One of the methods the artificial society applies is the withdrawal of information, as is seen in the novel when Shakuntala is in a dilemma over Kalyani's remarriage. Finds out about the 'recent' remarriage act. The act in question is in fact can into effect in 1856, almost 100 years before the era of the novel in the 1930s.

On the other hand, light on the situation comes in the form of Narayan the male protagonist and one of the few educated individuals in the novel. He is shown as a follower of Gandhiji and is a proponent of widow remarriage. His character is subtle subversion of societal norms and power dynamics. He eventually convinces Kalyani to marry him and leaves the city with her death. His interaction with Kalyani and further friendship work as a catalyst for her self-discovery and asserting of agency, allowing her to challenge society and envision a better future for herself.

In conclusion, analyzing *Water* through the lens of postcolonial, specifically Gayatri Spivak's essay "Can the Subaltern Speak?" offers us deep insights into the power dynamics of the era. While looking at the characters we find out how Power operates and perpetual identities and oppression.

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Chapter-2: Navigating Multiple Dimensions: Intersectionality in Bapsi Sidhwa's "Water"

Intersectionality was first coined by Kimberlé Crenshaw in 1989, it offers a powerful lens through which we can how multiple factors play a role in the subjugation of the widows instead of just

looking at it through a single perspective. The theoretical framework recognizes, that individuals hold intersecting identities based on factors such as gender, race, class sexuality, and more. These identities do exist alone but intersect and work together resulting in a unique form of oppression for each individual. By using intersectionality as an analytical tool, we can understand how power privilege and oppression operate on various axes of identity.

In the context of the text, we are allowed to explore the multifaceted identities of characters and how they intersect with the power dynamics and hierarchies present in colonial India. The novel contains a diverse range of characters the grapple with intersecting identities based on their gender, caste, class, and religion. through these experiences, the novel showcases the complex ways in which these identities intersect and influence their subjectivities.

one the primary axes of intersectionality explore in *Water* is the intersection of gender and caste. With the widows being women, their gender plays a significant role in presenting them in a subordinate position in the patriarchal society. However, when caste intersects gender, the oppression faced by the widows is further compounded. Even though most of the widows belong to the upper caste, the intersection of their status as a widow puts them on the fringes of society. For the lower caste widows, this subjugation and marginalization are intensified compared to their upper-class counterparts.

For case in point, Kalyani who was already a widow at a young age, was also segregated because of her work as a prostitute. In the ashram, she is somehow the most vital part, as her work puts the roof above their heads but also, the worst person because of her work. She is doubly subjugated both by society and the women in the ashram. Her intersectional experience differs from others as she is separated from the other widows and suffers further segregation.

Additionally, the intersection of religion and gender is also a crucial dimension explored in the novel. Most of the widows in the book identify as Hindu. Shakuntala recites a story from the

Mahabharat to Chuhiya regularly. But in the novel, their own religious beliefs are used as a mechanism of subjugation. Religions serve as a mechanism of control and dominate their behavior, appearances, and their places in society. The intersection of religion and gender further fortifies their subaltern position of the widows and restricts their free will. An example that shows intersectionality is the character of Shakuntala. As a Hindu widow, she is bound by the Hindu tradition and expectations made by the religion. The expectations and rituals she performs, bind her to widowhood. Her identity as a Hindu woman shapes her experiences within the ashram as she struggles to find a footing in the world outside the walls of the ashram and grapple with her identity. Her background as an educated woman helps in gaining an outside perspective and helps two of the youngest widows; Kalyan and Chuhiya, she is the one to seek information for Kalyani's remarriage and consequently releases Kalyani from her captivity. On the other hand, after realizing what could be Chuhiya's fate after Kalyani's unfortunate exit, she manages to send her away by giving her to Gandhi's following and inevitably giving Chuhiya a new release in life.

Through this lens, we gain a more profound understanding of the complexities of water. The novel's portal of intersecting identities and how interact, influence the characters' subjectivities, opportunities, and constraints. Intersectionality highlights how power works across different levels, shaping the characters' lives and reinforcing systems of oppression.

By using intersectionality as an analytical basis for the analysis of water, we can unravel the nuanced interplay between gender, caste, religion, and other dimensions. This particular approach allows us to discover the characters' struggles and their resistance to the intersecting power hegemonies of colonial India.

Gender plays a crucial role in the novel, particularly in the portal of the widows living in the ashram. The female characters are doubly marginalized in a patriarchal society that places women in a subordinate position but also places widows in a backward position while their male

counterparts get to live in normal society. The novel exposes the challenges faced by women in asserting their agency and finding their voices within a system that seeks to silence and control them.

One character that exemplifies the struggles is Kalyani, as a widow she confronts the limitation imposed on her by societal norms and expectations. Kalyani pines for independence and self-determination, but her gender and widowhood confine her to a life of discrimination. The novel explores Kalyani's inner conflicts as she grapples with societal expectations. Contracting her inner want to break free.

Caste is another crucial dimension of identity depicted in *Water*. The novel portrays the rigid caste-based societal structure that prevailed in colonial India and its impact on the lives of the characters. Caste determines one's social standing, occupation, and opportunities, leading to unequal power dynamics and hierarchies. The high-caste characters in the novel such as Chuhia and Shakuntala, are rendered helpless but their situation is still better than widows of lower castes faced in that era.

Additionally, the character's class position contributes to their experience and shapes their interactions within the novel. The widows in the ashram come from diverse class backgrounds, which impacts their access to resources, living conditions, and social status. For example, Shakuntala, who receives a small stipend from her brothers is in a different living condition from other widows. Another example of the same is when Madhumati is put in a position of power over the other widows because of her family's donation toward the temple that runs the ashram.

In conclusion, the exploration of intersectionality in Bapsi Sidhwa's "*Water*" provides a deeper understanding of the complex

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Conclusion

In Bapsi Sidhwa's "Water", the exploration of power dynamics, intersecting identities, and hierarchies in a hegemonic India provides a profound understanding of the complexities within the postcolonial narratives set in colonial India during the 1930s. The novel dives into the intersecting struggle of gender, caste, class, and religion, shedding light on how these dimensions work together to subjugate the subaltern. And how these factors influence the characters' identities, subjectivity, and opportunities. By examining these intersections, water invites the reader to understand and critically analyze the oppressive structures at play and the transformative potential of individual and collective agency.

In the novel, the characters' experiences reflect the wider power imbalance and power structures present in colonial India. The widows residing in the ashram, with their intersection of identities, bear the weight of the patriarchal oppression. As women, they face systemic marginalization and restriction imposed by a male-dominated society. As widows, they face discrimination due to the traditions and cultural norms prevalent during the era that casts them as impure and label them as 'burdens. The novel uncovers the complex layers of oppression faced by the widows, highlighting their resilience, struggles, and attempts to reclaim their self-will.

One of the central characters in "Water" Kalyani embodies the multidimensional aspects of identity and the negotiation of self in power enmities. As an impure widow; she does not shave her head and is employed in an unclean profession, prostitution. This limits her opportunities and reinforces the societal hierarchies. However Kalyani's character demonstrated remarkable agency and resilience as she seeks to challenge social norms and seeks to carve her path. Through her, the novel highlights the potential humans hold for individual resistance and reclamation of agency even in an oppressive world.

Additionally, the intersection of gender, caste, and class are intricately intertwined within the narrative, the widow's experiences are shaped not only by their gender and caste but also by their caste backgrounds. The characters from higher social classes like Shakuntala, get certain privileges and social standing albeit with the social constraints of widowhood. On the other hand, widows who do not have similar social standing are forced to work as a singer in the temple and beg for alms. Both of them are the only ways to guarantee them a meal a day, as the book supplies "For many widows, this was their only means of sustenance. On those days when a widow was too sick to perform, she starved." (Sidhwa 40) The novel explores the nuanced dynamics within these intersecting identities and invites the readers to examine to understand these complex social hierarchies and their impact on individuals.

Religion, as another dimension of identity, plays a significant role in shaping the characters' experiences and hence their subjectivities. In “Water”, the widows' adherence to Hindu transitions and rituals is both a source of peace and also a mechanism of control. Religious norms and practices are their behavior, appearance, and societal roles. However, the novel also uncovers moments of resistance and subversion as the characters challenge the oppressive notions of Hinduism. This exploration of religion within the context of intersecting identities underscores the complexities of human identity formation and the potential for individual growth and resistance within their own cultural and religious contexts.

By understanding the complexities of the intersection of identities in “water”, the novel presents a nuanced critique of the power dynamics and hierarchies prevalent in colonial India. It invites readers to contemplate on the transformative potential of individual and collective resistance against the oppressive practices. Through the characters' resistance, negotiations, and acts of defiance, the novel highlights the power of resilience and agency and emerges within the confines of intersecting oppressive structures.

Finally, “water” serves as a powerful exploration of intersecting industries and their relationship to power dynamics, hierarchies, and resistance. By diving into the complexities of gender, caste, class, and religion, the novel encourages readers to critically examine and question the structures that shape lives of individuals in the postcolonial context. It confronts us to recognize the interconnectedness of oppression and to work towards dismantling systems that sustain inequality and marginalization.

In conclusion, Bapsi Sidhwa’s *Water* offers a growing portal of the intersectionality of post-colonial identities and how gender, caste, class, and religion intersect and are influenced by the power hegemonies within the post-colonial narrative.

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